# The Art of Assembly

by Jonas Taylor



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**ISBN: 978-1-61387-303-8**

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**NICK**. (*to the paper instructions*) Okay, what comes next? What comes next?

(*to the audience*) I'm not trying to be melodramatic, but IKEA is evil. Seriously, look at this! In what world are these instructions useful? I have been working on this crib for weeks. And I know I'm not, like, Bob the Builder or anything, but I have a hard time believing this is my fault.

I almost got the crib together about a week ago, then Rachel, my wife, came in and said, "I think you built it upside down. It's supposed to have a bottom to sleep on, not a top to keep her in." And she was right. Instead of a crib for my firstborn child, I had built a Swedish cage.

Rachel says it's my soon-to-be-daddy nerves. But each night when I put my ear to her stomach and listen to that little heartbeat, I feel this stillness come over me. And I like to think it's calm, but maybe it is dread.

All I know is…she's almost here. Almost.

*When expecting parent, Nick, experiences the unexpected—the unimaginable—he learns that life isn't about putting the pieces together perfectly, it's about learning how to pick the pieces up after everything shatters.* The Art of Assembly *by Jonas Taylor*

**Nick**. I am getting used to the never-ending trips to Target. I almost have the aisles memorized. I can tell you off the top of my head the exact location of all of Rachel's snacks, the shortest route from the front door to the baby section, and that checkout lanes 3, 6, and 7 are all susceptible to computer problems. I think I am even starting recognize my favorite cart on sight.

And it astonishes me how much stuff we apparently need to care for a tiny human. There are carriers and seats, blankeys and binkys, and let me be clear: I have never been a prude, but buying the creams, wipes, and breast accessories has been a real test of my manhood. I asked Rachel how our ancestors did it without American Express. She says they fashioned shopping carts out of tortoise shells and hunted wild beasts to make blankets from pelts and binkys from the knuckle bones! And thus, the original Target was born! Well…we thought we were funny.

It just feels like more because we're doing most of the shopping at the last minute.

See, we didn't want to buy the baby stuff too soon because, well…we've had a lot of trouble getting pregnant. At first we

thought it was Rachel, and then we thought it was me, and then we thought it was God, and I'd ask, "What did I do to you?" You know? But it wasn't punishment, it just took patience. And even if it took a little longer than expected, she's almost here. So now I'm at Target all the time.

We picked out a name. I'm not supposed to tell anyone what it is, but it's Stella. I know, I know. It's bad luck. But isn't that just the prettiest name you've ever heard? Stella. Steeeeellllllaaaaaa.

Yep, that's my girl.

I'm home! Hello lovely baby oven, and hello little tiny bun.

(*He begins to sing horribly.*) "Well, I guess, you'd say, what can make me feel this way? My girl. My girl. Talking 'bout my girl." Hey, I think she likes it! She's kicking up a storm in there.

(*Rachel tells him to get back to work.*) Okay, okay. Back to the crib. Back to her crib.

Do you want to see a picture? That's what everybody says when I ask that question: big sigh and then a "sure." And I know that before they are born, it's just a black and white x-ray of my wife's stomach. But she's beautiful, especially for a blob. We just got this one last week; it's that kind of bumpy MRI image. And you can totally see a facial expression. The first time I saw it, I said "I know that facial expression! I've been married to that facial expression for seven years!" It's the look that says I've got a secret.

Well, I can't wait to find out what that secret is. My Stella.

*TRANSITION*

Morning, Rach. Before you start, I was up half the night, and the crib is done. It's done. I need to run a few more tests to make sure it's stable, but…what's wrong?

Weird? How? Like, do you think she's turning? The doctor said she was gonna start getting ready to drop soon…it could be. Not moving, at all? Well…honey, I'm sure she's just sleeping. Okay, okay. Calm down. Let me have a listen. (*He kneels and listens to the stomach. He hears nothing. Panic starts to build*.)

Nothing. I hear nothing. Okay, here's what we're going to do. We're gonna get in the car and go to the hospital. We are not gonna panic; we're not gonna call anyone. We're just gonna get in the car, go in, and get checked out. Just to be sure, okay? Just

to be sure.

TRANSITION

(*on the phone*) No. Don't, mom. There's nothing you can do. Nothing we can do. So, I'll pick you and Dad up at the airport tomorrow? Good. Yeah. Me, too. I'm sorry, too. Bye. (*hangs up*)

See, we got there, and they were great. They got us right in and got the sonogram and the heart monitor all set up. All the beeping, we thought it was a good thing. I even made a joke like, "Is all that beeping because she's swearing at us? Like, why the beep did you beeping beeps wake me up? I was beeping sleeping?" But...no one laughed.

That's when I knew something was wrong. Something horrible.

See, they…they couldn't find a heartbeat. The beeping meant that she wasn't...wasn't alive anymore. Stella. She's just gone.

We couldn't believe it.

I mean, this photo…this was last week! She was…

It's rare, they said, with no indication, to just lose a fetus so late. And I wanted to tell them off. You know, tell them we didn't lose her, and that she's not a fetus, she's Stella. But the words got closed up in my throat.

But, Rachel started screaming. She couldn't stop screaming. They had to sedate her. She's at the hospital still until tomorrow. When they will have to induce labor. And then, Rachel is going to have push and struggle and bring our first child into the world. But instead of bringing her home, we'll bury her.

And it would be one thing if we'd lost her at six, eight, thirteen weeks in. But after all this... tomorrow. This is wrong. It's so…so wrong. She was supposed to come home. The mobile, the wallpaper, that freaking crib. She was supposed to have all of this. And we were supposed to have her.

What did I do to you?

What did she do to you?

She was almost here. Almost.

She was so beautiful. My girl. I just hope you know how much we loved you. I think you did. My Stella.

I'm going to keep this, I think. Nothing else. Not the Target stuff or the crib…which I think we can all agree is probably for the best.

I am going to keep you, right here.

Well, I'd better go back to the hospital. For Rachel. For me. To figure out what comes next.